ETHICS
Module 3

SESSION TOPICS

- Culture as the basis of Moral Behavior
- Cultural Relativism
- Moral Relativism
- Multiculturalism

CULTURE AND MORAL BEHAVIOR

- We invoke the norms of our culture in deciding whether our choices mirror the true, the good, and the beautiful, or if it disgraces our cultural moral ideals.
- **Norms –** refer to social and cultural regulations and decrees that govern the everyday activities of people, inclusive of its moral and ethical imperatives, customs, and cultural practices (Barker, 2004).
- **Culture** is defined as the complex whole which includes, knowledge, beliefs, arts, morals, law, customs, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society (Burke, 2008).

WHY IS CULTURE IMPORTANT?

1. Culture provides identity to the people in the society
2. Culture mirrors the laws of the land
3. Culture unifies people in ways that only those who belong in that society understands
4. Culture influences our concept of morality

Moral behavior of people is clearly hinged from what was ingrained to him as right, proper, and acceptable in his cultural context.

How do you think your community influences your behavior?

THE FILIPINO WAY

Gorospe (1966): Distinct Filipino moral norms:

- Group-centeredness or Group Think
- "Don't be caught" attitude
- Complacency
- Rationalization

CULTURAL RELATIVISM:

Different strokes for different folks

- Cultural relativism – the view that moral beliefs and practices vary with and depend on the human needs and social conditions of particular cultures (Holmes, 2007).
- There is no culture that can be the basis of all that is good and true.

- It is important to recognize the vitality of cultural of cultural differences since ethical judgements are relative to cultural contexts.
- Morality can only be understood based on what is culturally acceptable or not in the society where we belong.
- Cultural relativism should be understood as a celebration and appreciation of cultural diversity (Kellenberger, 2011).

MORAL RELATIVISM

- In effect, cultural relativism results in moral relativism.
- What is "really right or wrong" is completely determined by the culture in which a person lives.
- It maintains that different societies (and ages) hold distinct systems; there is no objective and transcultural criteria for judging between these systems (Herder, as cited in Sikka, 2011).

How does cultural relativism promote moral relativism?

ETHNOCENTRISM

- the practice of taking one's own people, society, and culture to be the vantage point from which all else is viewed and judged (Bruce & Yearley, 2006).
- Ethnocentrism leads to the prejudgment of people.
- **Xenocentrism –** belief that one's own cultural features are a downgrade in comparison to those of the other cultures.

Which of the following statements are ethnocentric?

- Never trust anyone over thirty
- Turn off that junk heavy metal music so I can study
- I don't like classical music
- Politicians are selfish and corrupt
- My religion is the only religion which embodies truth
- Filipinos are very family-oriented
- The United States is the most economically powerful country on earth

CULTURAL RELATIVISM

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
Morally right and wrong should be judged based on cultural contexts.	**Cultural relativism might fall prey into the idea that universal standards do not exist.**

Cultural relativism is an answer to cultural annihilation.	**If universal standards do not exist, so thus morality.**
Cultural relativism promotes multiculturalism.	**Cultural relativism gives birth to ethical relativism, which veers away from the idea that there are objective moral standards.**

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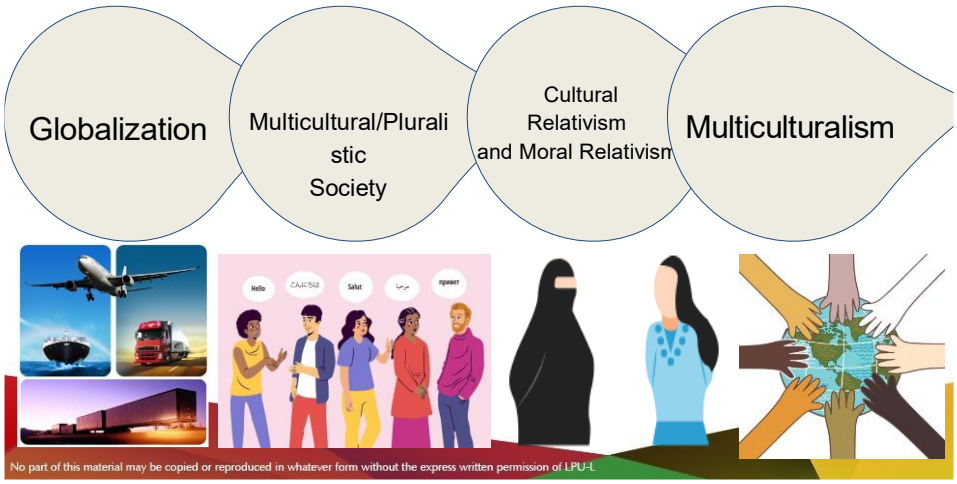
MULTICULTURALISM



How should societies with large immigrant populations deal with the problem of multiculturalism and relativism?

Should cultural diversity lead to moral diversity? Explain your answer.

CULTURAL TOLERANCE

- Cultural relativism should result in cultural tolerance to preserve people's distinctiveness regardless of whichever context they come from.
- Perpetuation of culture can only be possible through tolerance.
- How people value certain traditions in their culture is very much a part of who they are.
- Though cultural tolerance is highly encouraged, it would not mean that we are to compromise human life and all the universal rights associated with it.

- A particular culture cannot invoke cultural relativism at all times.
- Cultural sensitivity is the key to cultural tolerance.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Although diversity of cultures is heavily encouraged, this should be exclusive of customs and traditions which disrupt normal functioning.
- There still are moral absolutes which should precede cultural norms.
- Since we are all a product of our culture, our societal norms have always been the basis of our everyday decisions.

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